

Believing Without Desiring, Desiring Without
Believing: Against the Motivation Argument for Desire
As Belief

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Abstract

Alex Gregory (2021) champions the position known as ‘desire as belief’ (DAB): that to desire [that-p] *just is* to believe [that you have normative reason to bring about that-p].

Gregory’s primary positive argument for DAB is The Motivation Argument: certain beliefs can motivate, but only desires can motivate, therefore certain beliefs are desires. This paper examines the limited functionality that this argument can actually play in supporting DAB.

This paper’s argument proceeds in two stages. First, I demonstrate the formal limits of The Motivation Argument: it is neither a valid syllogism, nor is it formally valid at all. Charitably considered as abductive—in tension with its proclaimed unique force—The Motivation Argument can show, at best, that DAB is one possible explanation of its premises, rather than the only proper conclusion, as Gregory suggests.

Second, I argue that DAB is very unlikely to be the best possible abductive explanation of the relevant premises. Specifically, I deploy two thought experiments: Archer’s (2019) case, ‘Psychopathic Sam’—a counter-case of normative belief without desire—and a novel case, ‘Cult Collin’—a counter-case of archetypal desire (sexual desire) arising in the complete absence of relevant normative beliefs. Together, these generate trilemmas for DAB’s proponents that are both apparently problematic, and are not applicable to other prominent alternative accounts of desire.

I conclude that The Motivation Argument does not demonstrate DAB’s truth, nor does it show that DAB is the best explanation of its premises; further, there are substantial reasons to suppose that DAB is not the best explanation of these premises after all.

1 Introduction

The Motivation Argument is an especially important argument for the thesis of Desire as Belief (DAB): that ‘desires’ is a subset of ‘beliefs’. Alex Gregory characterises this argument as capable of convincing one of DAB’s truth, unlike other arguments, which merely support DAB’s theoretical virtues. If The Motivation Argument fails, DAB’s foundation is substantially weakened. In this essay, I argue that The Motivation Argument cannot adequately support the truth of DAB, nor can it adequately support the claim that DAB is the best possible explanation of its premises. Furthermore, I argue that there are compelling reasons to suppose that there is some alternative explanation of The Motivation Argument’s premises which is preferable to DAB. Moving away from DAB has substantial implications both theoretical (e.g., action theory and metaphysics of mind) and practical (e.g., addiction treatment).

I first outline Gregory’s characterisation of The Motivation Argument and its place in his broader argument for DAB, as well as its unique strength relative to his other arguments (§2). I begin my evaluation of this argument by highlighting its formal limits (§3). I demonstrate that the strongest version of The Motivation Argument is one that intends its conclusion to be the best explanation of the premises, rather than the only possible explanation. This leads me to consider whether this conclusion *is* in fact the best possible explanation (§4.1). I outline two good reasons to believe that an alternative explanation of the relevant premises is likely superior. Specifically, I pair Archer’s ‘Psychopathic Sam’ thought experiment with a novel thought experiment (Cult Collin). These thought experiments highlight deficits that can be avoided by alternative explanations of The Motivation Argument’s premises, and their centrality and intuitive appeal raise serious doubts about the claim that DAB is the best possible explanation of the relevant premises (§4.2). I notably do *not* conclude that The Motivation Argument (nor DAB) is altogether refuted; rather, I claim that The Motivation Argument neither establishes the truth of DAB nor that its conclusion is particularly well suited to explain its premises, and further there are good reasons to believe that DAB is not the best explanation of its premises (§5).

2 The Motivation Argument for Desire As Belief

Alex Gregory (2021) defends DAB as a substantial metaphysical account of the nature of desire. DAB is clarified as follows:

DAB “To desire [that-p] just is to believe [that you have reason to bring about that-p]” (Gregory 2021, p. 11).

... or, to incorporate some of Gregory’s additional qualifiers:

DAB ‘x desires [that-p]’ is equivalent to ‘x has an atomic, first-person, normative, reason belief (AFPNRB, henceforth) [that x has reason to bring about that-p]’ (Gregory 2021, pp. 8, 58).

Gregory defends this thesis against potential objections, and highlights some of its advantages, but his strongest arguments for DAB are his positive ones. The Motivation Argument (alongside The Rationality Argument) is one such argument intended to convince one of DAB’s truth.¹ The Motivation Argument is among Gregory’s strongest because—unlike appeals to parsimony and explanatory power (Gregory 2021, pp. 12, 28–29, 114–115)—it might convince one directly of DAB, rather than merely reinforcing its theoretical virtues; it is a genuine central positive argument for DAB which is ‘hard to reject’ (Gregory 2021, p. 54).

The Motivation Argument, as characterised by Gregory, is very simple and appealing. At multiple points, Gregory characterises the argument as follows:

“Motivation Internalism, roughly: [AFPNRBs] can motivate.

ODM, roughly: Only desires motivate.

∴ C: [AFPNRBs] are desires [i.e., DAB]” (Gregory 2021, pp. 54, 66).

Gregory stresses that this is a simplified version of The Motivation Argument, though it “captures the basic line of reasoning well enough” (Gregory 2021, p. 54). For the remainder of this essay, it is specifically this argument that I critically evaluate.²

¹One might roughly characterise DAB as a biconditional claim ($D \iff AFPNRB$), and The Motivation Argument as establishing one half of this biconditional ($AFPNRB \implies D$). If one characterises The Motivation Argument in this way, then it is important to note that—insofar as ($AFPNRB \implies D$) is necessary for DAB—my arguments can be thought to regard ($AFPNRB \implies D$) specifically *and* DAB more generally. That is, if The Motivation Argument fails to support ($AFPNRB \implies D$), so too does it fail to support DAB.

²This simplified articulation of the argument suffices for this paper, but I consider an ‘unsimplified’ articulation in Appendix B.

3 Formal Concerns

Rather than dwelling on the premises of The Motivation Argument, I will uncover some troubling formal concerns with the argument. The argument’s form initially suggests that it is intended to be read syllogistically:

Some AFPNRBs are Ms.

All Ms are Ds.

∴ All AFPNRBs are Ds.

... wherein *M* = ‘state-that-disposes-one-to-be-motivated’, and *D* = ‘desire’.

However, this syllogism form (traditionally written, *IAA*) is invalid.³ We might try to limit the conclusion of The Motivation Argument to claim only that *some* AFPNRBs are desires but this is a significantly weaker claim than Gregory intends (Gregory 2021, pp. 54, 66–67). Indeed, upon closer inspection, the argument is not deductively valid at all, even if the syllogistic form is abandoned in favour of a more in-depth contemporary form.⁴ Rather, the proposed conclusion is just one of many possible explanations of the premises. Of course, Gregory might think this is unproblematic, and simply claim that his conclusion is the *best* explanation of the premises rather than a strict formal implication. However, it is curious that Gregory would not *explicitly* frame The Motivation Argument as such, as he does with The Rationality Argument (Gregory 2019, p. 1075; 2021, p. 84). Further, Gregory does claim that the two premises—ODM and Motivation Internalism—“can be reconciled *only* by claiming that normative beliefs are desires”, which *very* closely resembles traditional definitions of deductive validity (Gregory 2021, p. 54). As such, it does seem that Gregory intends this argument to be more forceful than a typical abductive argument, but as the argument form is invalid, this cannot be so. Nevertheless, in the interest of examining a maximally charitable reading of The Motivation Argument, I will not necessarily consider this remark to commit Gregory to the claim that the argument is deductively valid, as if this is his intention, then it appears the argument must be disregarded outright.

For the above reasons, it seems best to consider the conclusion of The Motivation Argument to be intended as the best explanation, rather than the only possible explanation,

³See (Appendix A)

⁴See (Appendix B)

of its premises. As such, I will evaluate whether The Motivation Argument justifies the following claim: ‘AFPNRBs are desires’ is the best explanation of ODM and Motivation Internalism. However, this cannot be adequately supported by The Motivation Argument alone; outside help is required.⁵ That is, there are many other potential conclusions that the premises are consistent with. For example, consider any alternative conclusion wherein AFPNRBs [that one has reason to bring about that-p] merely disposes one to desire [that-p]. These formal concerns alone may prompt one to entirely disregard The Motivation Argument—especially if one lends particular weight to Gregory’s claim that only one conclusion is reconcilable with the relevant premises—but if we accept that the argument is abductive, then the next step in its evaluation is determining if Gregory’s conclusion is indeed the *best* explanation of the premises.

4 What is the Best Possible Explanation?

Although it is beyond the scope of this essay to defend any particular alternative, it is helpful to have a specific example in mind whilst considering if Gregory’s is the best explanation of ODM and Motivation Internalism. Consider again some account of desire wherein AFPNRBs and desires are closely related—perhaps certain desires supervene on AFPNRBs. On such an account, one may say that only desires motivate, and she may well also say that some AFPNRBs motivate, though perhaps this is caveated by the suggestion that AFPNRBs merely *dispose* us to desire, which in turn disposes us to act, rather than ‘directly’ disposing us to act. Even if one thinks such an account of desire problematic for whatever reason, though, as long as we can accept that there are any such competing theories that are consistent with the relevant premises, then we have to carefully assess whether Gregory’s conclusion is in fact the best possible explanation.

4.1 Comparing Alternatives

The fact that there are multiple possible explanations of The Motivation Argument’s premises highlights an interesting point regarding the methodology of abductive arguments, and assessing such arguments. Namely, if two or more accounts are consistent with the evidence (or premises), then the process of deciding which is preferable must be

⁵Consider, as an example of said ‘outside help’, Gregory’s rejection of non-cognitivism (Gregory 2021, pp. 55–66).

cumulative. That is, even if we highlight that there are some very troubling counterintuitive results that stem from a particular conclusion, this does not necessarily prove that it is not the best explanation. To definitively decide whether a given explanation of the premises is, or is not, the *best* explanation, we must weigh the benefits and drawbacks of various coherent explanations.⁶ However, if one can articulate a particularly central counterintuitive result of one explanation that is not applicable to some alternative explanation(s), then this gives us some substantial reason to doubt that said explanation is the best possible explanation. It is this method that I will use (in §4.2) to demonstrate that there are substantial reasons to doubt that DAB is the best explanation of The Motivation Argument’s premises.

4.2 Disadvantages of DAB

In support of the claim that DAB is likely not the best explanation of ODM and Motivation Internalism, I put forward two thought experiments: (4.2.1) Archer’s ‘Psychopathic Sam’ objection and (4.2.2) ‘Cult Collin’: a novel example of recalcitrant desire that is particularly problematic for DAB. Together, these thought experiments highlight some very undesirable commitments of DAB and lend some credence to the idea that The Motivation Argument’s premises are likely better explained by an alternative conclusion.

4.2.1 Psychopathic Sam

Archer supposes the Psychopathic Sam example as a counterexample to DAB (Archer 2019, pp. 240 ff.). The core of Archer’s thought experiment is as follows:

Sam believes that he has very good normative reasons to stop torturing animals (on account of his thorough study of metaethics), but he has absolutely no desire to do so (on account of his psychopathy, and his enjoyment of animal-torture) (Archer 2019, p. 240).

This strikes us as a possible state of affairs, and Archer defends the possibility of this example thoroughly (Archer 2019, *esp.* pp. 247–250). We need not even think that this is a physically manifestable state of affairs; we need only accept that this is conceivable.⁷

⁶In large part, this is what Gregory’s (2021) book aims to do.

⁷Of course, not all forms of conceivability imply metaphysical possibility. This is not a strict requirement for my argument, but I do think it is apparent that the case of Psychopathic Sam implies possibility. Two notable potential failure modes are worth addressing. First, Taliaferro draws attention to difficulties that arise when a thought experiment relies on imagining an absence: where the absent quality would leave no phenomenally detectable mark, it is unclear that one has formed genuine positive conception at

That is, the mere fact that we can imagine such a character as Sam and affirm that he believes that he has normative reasons to bring about a particular state of affairs but absolutely no desire to do so shows that we, at least in this instance, do not *conceive* of desires as identical with AFPNRBs. Of course, Gregory might argue that we are in error when we think or speak of desire in this way; indeed, DAB is not committed to explaining all ordinary thought and language, it need only overlap substantially (Gregory 2021, pp. 19, 29, 37, 155). Gregory would be right to highlight that this counterintuitive result alone does not suffice to *disprove* that DAB is the best possible explanation of the relevant premises. However, it certainly does remain a substantial reason to doubt that claim, especially due to the clarity of Sam’s case. Ultimately, this results in a trilemma for all proponents of DAB, wherein they must affirm either that:

- a) Sam does desire to stop torturing animals.
- b) Sam does not believe he has any normative reason to stop torturing animals.
- c) Sam’s case, as described, is altogether impossible.

None of these claims are at all appealing. (a) directly contradicts the stipulated conditions of the case: Sam’s psychopathy and his continued enjoyment of and enacting of animal cruelty are precisely what excludes any such desire to stop; indeed, he has no desire to stop whatsoever. To deny this is to refuse engagement with the example on its own terms. (b) is equally untenable: it is Sam’s metaethical study that grounds his normative belief about what he *should* do, and denying that any such study can lead to the development of normative beliefs is an extremely costly commitment. This leaves only (c), which is the least appealing option: denying that any person like Sam could exist requires a thorough metaphysical argument that Gregory does not supply. Indeed, it seems very plausible that Sam could exist. At the very least, each route out of this trilemma results in a very unnatural way of speaking, and that alone is reason to suppose that DAB is unlikely to be the best explanation of ODM and Motivation Internalism.

Notably, the Psychopathic Sam example is far less problematic for alternative explana-

all, rather than just failing to conceive of something (Taliaferro 1997, pp. 130–131). This difficulty does not arise in this case: we are not imagining the undetectable absence of something; we are conceiving of a person with a familiar and detectable psychological profile (sincerely endorsing a normative belief but being unmoved by it). Second, Kripke identifies a further failure mode arising from intermediaries: when one seemingly imagines heat without molecular motion, one is in fact imagining the experiential correlate of heat, rather than heat itself (Kripke 1980, pp. 129–131, 151–152). No such mistake is liable to arise here because beliefs, desires, and mental states are accessible to our conception in a way that physical, external phenomena are not. Accordingly, the conceivability, and consequent possibility, of this state of affairs seems entirely unproblematic on modal epistemological grounds, as well as *prima facie*.

tions of the relevant premises. Consider again the aforementioned alternative explanation (cf. §4). On such an account, we might say that Sam, as a symptom of his psychopathy, is not disposed to desire [that-p] when he has the AFPNRB [that he has reason to bring about that-p]. This is consistent with ODM and Motivation Internalism, and explains Sam’s behaviour when he appears unmotivated [to ϕ] even when he believes [that ϕ -ing would bring about that-p]. No such recourse is apparently available for DAB. This observation goes beyond merely showing that alternative accounts avoid some unpalatable commitments of DAB. Our reason for accepting Motivation Internalism—the first premise of The Motivation Argument—is itself intuitive: we imagine and consider cases wherein someone has such an AFPNRB, and it motivates their action. DAB must deny the Psychopathic Sam case to preserve Motivation Internalism, but Sam’s case is supported in just the same way as Motivation Internalism is. Thus, an alternative account is likely to offer a better explanation, as it completely sidesteps this methodological tension.

4.2.2 Cult Collin

I offer a thought experiment that indicates that one can have desire despite having no corresponding AFPNRB. That is, a counterexample to the other direction of DAB’s biconditional claim. In conjunction with Psychopathic Sam, Cult Collin demonstrates that it is intuitive to suppose that desire can persist without AFPNRB, *and* AFPNRB can persist without desire; thus, AFPNRBs are *not* identical to desires. The Cult Collin example is explained in more depth than the Psychopathic Sam example, as it is not already outlined elsewhere in the literature:

From birth, Collin has lived in a remote cult, disconnected from all other civilisation and culture. He was raised and taught all he knows by a small, very devoted commune. His whole life, Collin has been taught, without deviation, of the dangers of engaging in sexual activity. As a result, Collin believes that, not only will he burn in hell for eternity if he engages in sexual activity, but also that sexual acts themselves are extremely painful, and that there is no functional reason for them—i.e., Collin is ignorant of the concept of reproduction altogether. At one point in Collin’s life, while spending some time with another cult member, he inexplicably (at least, from Collin’s perspective) is compelled to pursue sexual activity with this person. It would

appear that Collin has absolutely no AFPNRB [that he has reason to engage in sexual activity with this person] and yet he still seems to desire, and even be motivated to act towards, this end.

This case is similar in some respects to other examples of recalcitrant desire. However, the Cult Collin example is particularly apt for the present discussion for two reasons: Firstly, this example strikes me as very plausible; we can indeed imagine that someone might *actually* be born into such a cult, and need not posit anything from science fiction. Secondly, sexual desire is so *clearly* a case of ‘desire’ or ‘want’, that the word ‘desire’ often is used exclusively to refer to sexual desires, as is noted explicitly by Gregory (Gregory 2021, pp. 6–7). Again, though it might be possible to argue that in such a case we are mistaken to call what Collin experiences ‘desire’, it seems that this is a particularly hard pill to swallow in this case, as Gregory himself categorises sexual desire as paradigmatically desire (Gregory 2021, pp. 6–7). Indeed, this is perhaps *the* archetypal example of desire. Further, it is intuitive to say that Collin would be motivated (to some extent) to *act* in these circumstances, and as Gregory has himself posited: *only desires motivate* (Gregory 2021, pp. 25–36). Thus, Gregory cannot suppose that we are in error in this case, as we have concluded that Collin desires by Gregory’s own reasoning. This gives us substantial reason to doubt DAB’s status as the best explanation of ODM and Motivation Internalism. Similarly to the Psychopathic Sam example, Cult Collin ultimately results in a trilemma for Gregory’s explanation of the premises, wherein one must affirm one of the following—seemingly thoroughly unsatisfactory—claims:

- d) Collin does believe he has some normative reason to engage in sexual activity.
- e) Collin has no desire to engage in sexual activity, and is thus motivated by something other than desire.
- f) Collin’s case, as described, is altogether impossible.

As with the previous trilemma, Gregory could bite the bullet on any of these claims, but this would certainly make DAB far less appealing. (d) is contradicted by the conditions of the case: Collin has been explicitly and consistently taught that there are no reasons to engage in sexual activity. There is simply no route by which he could have formed the belief that he has normative reason to pursue it. (e) goes against Gregory’s own premise, ODM. Finally, in precisely the same manner as (c), (f) is an entirely unjustified

and thoroughly unappealing claim.⁸

Again, these commitments are avoidable by alternative explanations of The Motivation Argument's premises. According to the alternative conclusion previously outlined (cf. §4), one could explain Collin's circumstances by simply saying that Collin has a desire, but no relevant normative beliefs. This recourse is, for obvious reasons, not available to proponents of DAB.

In both of the above thought experiments—Psychopathic Sam and Cult Collin—ODM and Motivation Internalism can both be affirmed without identifying AFPNRBs and desires. Further, Gregory's explanation of these premises seems very problematic in light of these thought experiments; this demonstrates issues with DAB both when AFPNRBs occur without desire, and when desires occur without AFPNRB. As such, these thought experiments provide substantial reason to doubt that DAB is the best explanation of The Motivation Argument's premises.

The difficulties posed both by Psychopathic Sam and Cult Collin are not merely problems for DAB as compared to some arbitrary hypothetical alternative. Rather, they are problems that arise as a result of DAB, and dissolve entirely on traditional accounts of desire wherein desire is a distinct mental kind, not reducible to or identical with any kind of belief. Neither do these examples pose any problems for 'cluster concept' theories of desire—wherein 'desires' bear a family relation to one another, rather than being defined by a set of necessary criteria—such as that proposed by Goldman (2017). The ready availability of alternative accounts for which these thought experiments are entirely unproblematic strengthens our reason for doubting that DAB is the best explanation of The Motivation Argument's premises substantially. Which particular account is ultimately preferable is beyond the scope of this essay. What has been shown is that The Motivation Argument cannot provide reason to prefer DAB over the available alternatives.

5 Conclusion

Altogether, I have shown that The Motivation Argument does not conclusively show DAB to be true (§3), nor does it establish outright that DAB is the best explanation of its premises (§4.1); and further, I have shown that there are good reasons to doubt

⁸See again, Footnote 7.

that DAB is the best explanation of these premises (§4.2). Though this essay alone does not settle the issue of whether DAB is preferable to any particular competing theory, it does clearly demonstrate the limits of The Motivation Argument. To determine if DAB is the best explanation overall, one must consider the counterintuitive results (e.g., rejecting ‘basic desires’ as desires), the intuitive results (e.g., explaining the apparently close link between normative beliefs and desires), the simplicities (e.g., commitment to one fewer type of mental state (desire being a subset of belief)), and the complexities (e.g., those introduced regarding ‘degrees of desire’), etc., and ultimately decide whether their combination yields an account that is overall superior to other explanations.⁹ The thought experiments outlined in this essay (§4.2) demonstrate substantial disadvantages of DAB. Thus, despite apparently being Gregory’s strongest argument, The Motivation Argument fails.

The Motivation Argument does not establish the truth or preferability of the thesis that desire is belief about reasons; a thesis which has been demonstrated to be substantially doubtful. This is illuminating in and of itself, but (as with many conclusions in this area of philosophy) it also has important practical implications. To give one example, if DAB is false then healthcare professionals can treat patients suffering from addiction in a manner that does not ascribe to them normative beliefs about their addiction; normative beliefs that they may themselves deny having. If these patients are taken to believe things they do not—as they would be if DAB was mistakenly endorsed—this might significantly hinder their recovery; and so if DAB is taken to be true when it is not, substantial harm is liable to be caused. DAB remains highly dubious, and this is important for the philosophy of desire and beyond.

⁹For Gregory’s treatments of the mentioned examples of virtues and vices of DAB, see (Gregory 2021, pp. 17–19, 146–147, 149).

A

The Invalidity of ‘The Motivation Syllogism’

Invalid syllogism form:

1. Some AFPNRBs are M.
2. All Ms are D.
3. All AFPNRBs are D.

Counter-model:

Let the domain contain three objects: a_1, a_2, a_3

$$M = \{a_1\}$$

$$D = \{a_1, a_2\}$$

$$AFPNRB = \{a_1, a_2, a_3\}$$

In this case (3) is false, but (1) and (2) remain true. Therefore, the syllogism is invalid.

B

The Invalidity of The Motivation Argument

Formalisation of The Motivation Argument with the most minimal conclusion one can reasonably understand Gregory to intend:

1. $\exists x[\exists p[\exists \phi[AFPNRB(x, p) \ \& \ B(x, C(\phi, p)) \ \& \ M(x, \phi) \ \& \ E(AFPNRB(x, p), M(x, \phi))]]]$

Motivation Internalism

2. $\forall x[\forall \phi[\exists p[M(x, \phi) \implies (D(x, p) \ \& \ B(x, C(\phi, p)) \ \& \ E(D(x, p), M(x, \phi)))]]]]$

ODM

3. $\forall x[\forall \phi[\forall p[AFPNRB(x, p) \implies D(x, p)]]]$

Conclusion

$M(a, b)$	“a is motivated to b”
$D(a, b)$	“a desires b”
$B(a, b)$	“a believes b”
$C(a, b)$	“a brings about b”
$E(F(a, b), G(c, d))$	“ $F(a, b)$ explains $G(c, d)$ ”
$AFPNRB(a, b)$	“a believes that she has a first-person normative reason to bring about b”

Table 1: Predicate Key

Counter-model:

$Domain = \{a, b, \phi_1, \phi_2, p_1, p_2\}$

- $AFPNRB(a, p_1)$
- $AFPNRB(b, p_2)$
- $D(a, p_1)$
- $\sim D(b, p_2)$
- $B(a, C(\phi_1, p_1))$
- $B(b, C(\phi_2, p_2))$
- $M(a, \phi_1)$
- $\sim M(b, \phi_2)$

In this case (3) is false, but (1) and (2) remain true. Therefore, the argument is invalid.

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